

Board: 1

Dealer: **West**

Contract: 3NT

Declarer: North

Lead: ♣K

Board: 2

Dealer: **East**

Contract: 4♠

Declarer: East

Lead: ♦A

Board: 3

Dealer: **South**

Contract: 4♠

Declarer: South

Lead: ♦2

Board: 4

Dealer: **South**

Contract: 3NT

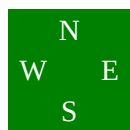
Declarer: West

Lead: ♥Q

Board 1
West Deals
None Vul

♠ J 9 8 4
♥ Q 10 3
♦ K 9 2
♣ 9 6 3

♠ K 7 3
♥ A 6 4
♦ Q J 10 5
♣ A 8 2



♠ 10 5 2
♥ J 9 8
♦ 6 4
♣ K Q J 10 4

♠ A Q 6
♥ K 7 5 2
♦ A 8 7 3
♣ 7 5

West	North	East	South
Pass	1♦	Pass	1♥
Pass	1NT	Pass	3NT
All Pass			
3NT by North			
Lead: ♣K			

With 14 points you will naturally open the bidding. You should open a 4-card ♦ suit rather than a 3-card ♣ suit. Partner responds 1♥.

Partner might have bid a 4-card suit so you cannot support ♥s with only 3. Instead, you describe your balanced, minimum opener by bidding 1NT. Partner then bids 3NT and you pass.

North plays 3NT. East leads the ♣K.

North plays 3NT. East leads the ♣K.

Winners: ♠ 3 : ♥ 2 : ♦ 1 : ♣ 1 : Total = 7

You need to find 2 more winners and they can come from the ♦ suit. You can finesse East for the ♦K. If he has it then you will get 3 extra tricks, but even if West has the ♦K you can still make 2 winners.

The problem is that if you win the first or second ♣ and then try the ♦ finesse West may win and still have a ♣ to lead back to his partner. So you should hold up the ♣A until the third round of the suit. Then if West wins the ♦K he may not have another ♣.

Imagine that you had won either the first or second ♣. When West won the ♦K he would still have had a ♣ to return to East's hand. You would have lost 4 ♣ tricks and the ♦K.

But what if West **DID** have another ♣ when he won the ♦K?

Suppose you held up until the third ♣. When West won the ♦K here he had a fourth ♣ to return to East's hand. That means the ♣ suit split 4-4 so you would have lost only 3 ♣ tricks and the ♦K.

Board 2

East Deals

N-S Vul

♠ Q 7 2
 ♥ K Q 8 6
 ♦ Q 9 2
 ♣ K Q 7

♠ 10
 ♥ 10 9 7 4 2
 ♦ 7 3
 ♣ 10 9 5 4 2

	N	
W		E
	S	

♠ A K 8 6 5 4
 ♥ J
 ♦ 8 6
 ♣ A J 8 3

♠ J 9 3
 ♥ A 5 3
 ♦ A K J 10 5 4
 ♣ 6

West	North	East	South
3♦	Pass	1♠	2♦
All Pass		4♠	
4♠ by East			
Lead: ♦ A			

then ♦ J. North discards on the second ♦ and ruffs the third one with the ♠ T.

Losers: ♠ 0? : ♥ 1 : ♦ 2? : ♣ 0 : Total = 3?

The loser count looks a little messy - that's because of the circumstances. If you could have just played three rounds of ♠s you would probably have had 0 losers, and if you ruff this ♦ you will have only 2 ♦ losers, but maybe create a ♠ loser.

But though the loser count is confused your plan should not be. You **DO NOT** over-ruff the ♠ 10. Instead you discard your one ♥ loser (a loser-on-loser play). North can have this trick but whatever he returns you will win, pull trumps in **THREE** rounds if necessary, and take the rest of the tricks.

Discarding the ♥ loser instead of over-ruffing was the winning Plan. If you had over-ruffed you would have lost the ♥, but you would also have to lose a trump. You made a good play.

But did you notice that South made a bad play? He should have cashed his ♥ A before he led the third ♦ for his partner to ruff. Then when his partner ruffed with the ♠ 10 your goose would have been cooked.

You have an easy 1♠ opening bid.

But South overcalls 2♦ and partner bids 3♦.

You should be certain to have a partnership agreement on the meaning of a cue-bid after an overcall.

Most good players use it to show support for opener's suit and at least 11 points. In other words, a hand with which you would have made a limit-raise or better.

So you bid the ♠ game.

East plays 4♠. South leads the ♦ A, then ♦ K, then ♦ J. North discards on the second ♦ and ruffs the third one with the ♠ 10.

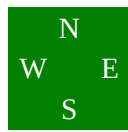
East plays 4♠. South leads the ♦ A, then ♦ K,

Board 3

South Deals
None Vul

♠ J 6
♥ Q 10 5 3
♦ K 10 7 2
♣ Q 9 5

♠ A 9 8 3
♥ A K 7 2
♦ 9 6 5
♣ 8 3



♠ Q 10 4
♥ J 9 8
♦ Q J 4
♣ J 10 7 2

♠ K 7 5 2
♥ 6 4
♦ A 8 3
♣ A K 6 4

West	North	East	South
			1♣
Pass	1♥	Pass	1♠
Pass	3♠	Pass	4♠
All Pass			
4♠ by South			
Lead: ♦ 2			

North would play 4♠.

South plays 4♠. West leads the ♦ 2. East plays ♦ J.

South plays 4♠. West leads the ♦ 2. East plays ♦ J.

Losers: ♠ 1 : ♥ 0 : ♦ 2 : ♣ 2 : Total = 5

Counting losers from the South hand you have 2 ♣ losers to get rid of. If you had counted from the North hand there would have been 2 ♥ losers to get rid of. In any case the plan is the same.

Win the ♦ A and play ♠ A and ♠ K. If the ♠ s split 3-2 you are home-free. Leave the master trump out and play your ♣ A K and dummy's ♥ A K. Then cross-ruff ♣ s and ♥ s. Whichever defender holds the last trump is welcome to ruff with it at any time. The defense is also welcome to take their 2 ♦ s at any time. Your 10 tricks are safe.

This is another example of the general principle to leave a master trump out.

North and South were able to make all their small trumps individually.

If East ruffs the fourth ♥ with his master ♠ Q South just discards a ♦ loser and makes an overtrick.

There is an excellent bidding guideline which tells you how to respond with two 4-card Majors. You bid them "up-the-line". That means you bid 1♥.

Partner's rebid is 1♠.

This hand shows why responder should bid "up-the-line". Partner can now show a 4-card ♠ suit at the 1-level. Imagine the suits reversed - you first respond with 1♠. If partner wanted to show a ♥ suit he would have to go to the 2-level, and he might not have the strength to do so.

Back to the actual situation. Over partner's 1♠ bid you jump to 3♠. This jump shows about 11-12 points and good ♠ support (4 cards). In case you thought this showed 13 or more points that wouldn't be logical. If you had 13 points and 4 ♠ s you would jump all the way to game. So 3♠ is invitational. Partner accepts the invitation.

Board 4

South Deals

Both Vul

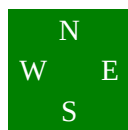
♠ A 9 8 3
♥ A K 7
♦ A 9 8 6
♣ 7 4

♠ K 6 5 2

♥ Q J 10 2

♦ Q 7 3

♣ Q 8



♠ J 4

♥ 6 5 3

♦ J 4

♣ A K 9 6 5 2

♠ Q 10 7

♥ 9 8 4

♦ K 10 5 2

♣ J 10 3

West	North	East	South
1NT	Pass	3NT	Pass

All Pass

3NT by West

Lead: ♥Q

and then a small one you'll be sorry. Those extra three ♣s will be established as winners but you will have no entry to them.

Instead, you play your ♣4 to the second trick and also play a low card from dummy. This is called Ducking the trick. South/North will certainly win that trick, but you are in control. You can win whatever suit they play and you still have that ♣7 to reach dummy's solid ♣s.

You can see that with ♣s splitting 3-2 the Duck insures the contract.

But just imagine you had played ♣A, ♣K, ♣2. At that point ♣ 9 6 5 would all be winners, but don't think South is going to let you reach dummy with either of those two Jacks!

You have 15 points and you have a balanced distribution. You should open 1NT. It is true that you do not have ♣s stopped, but you are not required to have a stopper in all the suits to open 1NT. Partner jumps to 3NT and you pass.

West plays 3NT. North leads the ♥Q.

West plays 3NT. North leads the ♥Q.

Winner count: ♠ 1 : ♥ 2 : ♦ 1 : ♣ 2 : Total = 6

In many Notrump hands it is good to hold up to disrupt the defender's communications. In this hand you have a double-stopper in ♥s but only a single stop in ♠s and ♦s so win the first trick.

You need 3 more tricks from the ♣ suit. As long as the ♣s split 3-2, which is very likely, you can set up the tricks you need. **BUT**, if you just play ♣A ♣K